

Rise of revolutionary parties

With violence erupting in city streets, the Czar abdicated in March, having relinquished power to the Provisional Government in February, with Prince Georgi Y. Lvov as its head. The government still represented only the middle classes and continued to back Russia's involvement in World War I. Groups such as the Petrograd Soviet of Workers and Soldiers, a council made up of workers and peasants agitating for change, grew stronger and gained power within the Provisional Government. Lenin, in exile for revolutionary activities, was anxious to return to Petrograd, convinced that the collapse of world capitalism was imminent. He received the help of the German government, which hoped that he could further destabilize the political situation in Russia for their war effort, and arrived secretly in a sealed train. Full of revolutionary zeal, he was determined to shape a new Russian government according to his ideas, and he accused his associates of not doing enough to overthrow the current regime.

Prime Minister Lvov resigned after the disastrous July Offensive on the Eastern Front. His successor, Alexander Kerensky, formed a new socialist government with the Petrograd Soviet, but he, too, insisted on keeping Russia in the war. After mass demonstrations in Petrograd encouraged by the Bolsheviks, Kerensky banned them

and arrested many of their leaders. Lenin fled to Finland.

Revolution is nigh

In August, Kerensky faced a new threat. General Lavr Kornilov, Russia's army commander-in-chief, ordered troops into Petrograd. Kerensky believed that Kornilov was plotting to seize power. In desperation, he released the Bolsheviks, who armed those who wanted to prevent a counterrevolution. This was a massive boost for their cause. They were able to represent themselves to the people as defenders of Petrograd. By September, the Bolsheviks had taken control of the Petrograd Soviet. Lenin seized the moment, returned to Russia, and renewed calls for revolution. He handed responsibility for military tactics to Leon Trotsky, a fellow Marxist. Peasants and farmers were revolting in rural areas, workers in the cities. Lenin decided the time was ripe for a Bolshevik seizure of power. The Bolsheviks took government buildings and the Winter Palace, where Kerensky's cabinet had sought refuge.

On the night of October 25 (November 7, GC), Lenin issued a brief address to the Russian people: "The Provisional

This painting of the storming of the Winter Palace portrays the dramatic moment in the October Revolution when the Bolsheviks seized the government building.

